Game: Herald Dispatch

Instructor guide · Req 4e · 5 minutes (2 read, 2 report, 1 vote)

Before class

The six articles (pages 2-7) are in the full Herald Dispatch file in Final Docs, not in the print pack: share each lodge its article on a device, or print them only if you want paper copies. The Warden report sheet (page 8) is in the Per-Warden Print Pack. Page 9 (the answer key) is also in that full file. The articles are rewritten in plain language from real news reports, so they are not graphic. Confirm the facts once more before class, because breach numbers keep being updated.

Run it

1) Hand each lodge its article. Read quietly for 2 minutes (use the timer on the slide). 2) Each Warden gives a 30-second news report to their lodge: what happened, how it happened, what it cost the victim (about 15 seconds each in a lodge of 4-5). Wardens fill in the report sheet for Req 4e. 3) Each lodge votes for its clearest reporter, who gives the report to the whole class. **Points:** +2 for each lodge's winning reporter, +1 for any lodge that identifies the cause correctly.

Tie it back

After the reports, ask: which attacks did we play about today? Phishing (PowerSchool, Discord), password reuse (23andMe), ransomware (M&S, Change Healthcare), and attacks that stop things working (JLR, M&S). Ask which CIA corner each one hit (all hit confidentiality or availability).

Copy-paste prompt: make fresh articles right before class

Paste this into an AI assistant that can search the web (replace the date in brackets). Always check the facts and source links yourself before printing.

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Act as a news writer for a Scouting America Cybersecurity merit badge class. Today's date is [TODAY'S DATE]. Use web search to find 6 real cyber incidents or data breaches reported in the last 12 months. Pick a mix: one involving a school or students, one involving a gaming or chat app, one caused by password reuse or a stolen login, one ransomware attack that stopped a business, one involving a health or hospital company, and one involving a third-party vendor. For each one, write a one-page news article for Wardens aged 11 to 17: a headline, then 3 short paragraphs (about 150 to 200 words total) in plain language, and 3 vocabulary words with one-sentence definitions. The article must make clear what happened, how it happened, and what it cost the victim. Use only facts that reputable news sources report, with exact dates and numbers. If the cause or the person responsible is unconfirmed or disputed, say so plainly. No graphic detail, no real victims' names, and no instructions for attacking anything. After the six articles, add an answer key table with columns: what happened, how it happened, cost to the victim, and what could have stopped it. Finish with a list of the source URLs you used for each article. Format the result so I can print one article per page.
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If time is short

Cut the report to 20 seconds, or have only one volunteer per lodge report.

Stories: 1 PowerSchool (schools) · 2 Discord support vendor (gaming and chat) · 3 23andMe (password reuse) · 4 Marks & Spencer (ransomware) · 5 Change Healthcare (health care) · 6 Jaguar Land Rover (factories). Sources are listed on the answer key.

THE CYBER DAILY

A Stolen Login Opens the Door to Millions of School Records

PowerSchool makes software that many schools use to keep student information, such as grades, addresses and attendance. In late December 2024, attackers used a stolen login for a support portal that PowerSchool staff use to help schools. Once inside, they used a maintenance tool to reach school databases and copy student and teacher records.

The stolen data included names, addresses and birth dates. For some people it also included Social Security numbers and medical information. The company told schools in early January 2025 and made the breach public a few days later. Court papers later put the number of people affected at about 62 million.

The attackers demanded about $2.85 million and PowerSchool reportedly paid. Even so, extortion emails with samples of the data reached some schools months later. A 19-year-old was later charged in the case.

Words to know

- **Credentials:** A username and password, or other login details.
- **Data breach:** When private information is copied or seen by people who should not have it.
- **Extortion:** Demanding payment by threatening to harm or leak something.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

THE CYBER DAILY

Chat App's Help Desk Partner Breached

Discord is a chat app with more than 200 million monthly users. On September 20, 2025, criminals broke into a company that handles customer support for Discord. Discord's own servers were not attacked. The criminals got to information that the support company held.

Discord told users on October 3. Everyone affected had their names, Discord usernames, email addresses and messages with support agents exposed. Some also had IP addresses and limited billing details, such as the last four digits of a credit card. A small number of people who had appealed an age check had pictures of government IDs exposed.

The attack appeared to be about money. The criminals reportedly demanded a ransom. Discord cut off the support company's access, brought in outside experts, and warned users to trust only emails from noreply@discord.com. Discord says it never phones users.

Words to know

- **Third-party vendor:** An outside company that does a job for another company and can reach its data.
- **Ransom:** Money demanded to give back or not leak stolen data.
- **Phishing:** A fake message that tricks you into clicking or giving up secrets.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

THE CYBER DAILY

Reused Passwords Let Hackers Into a DNA Website

23andMe is a company that tests DNA and helps people find relatives. In October 2023 it said hackers had broken into customer accounts. The hackers used a trick called credential stuffing. They took usernames and passwords leaked from other websites and tried them on 23andMe to see which ones still worked.

About 14,000 accounts were opened that way. Then a feature that lets users see matches with relatives let the hackers see profile information on about 6.9 million people. Some of it was posted online.

23andMe said many people had reused passwords from other sites. It made every customer reset their password and then required two-factor authentication. Lawyers in lawsuits argued about how much of the blame belonged to users. Unlike a password, your DNA information cannot be changed.

Words to know

- **Credential stuffing:** Trying stolen usernames and passwords on many sites, hoping people reused them.
- **Two-factor authentication:** A second step, such as a code from your phone, to prove it is you.
- **Password reuse:** Using the same password on more than one site.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

THE CYBER DAILY

Big Store Chain Hit by Ransomware

Marks & Spencer is a major store chain in the United Kingdom. In April 2025 it took some services offline after a cyberattack. Reports say the attackers had broken in earlier and, around April 24, locked computer servers with ransomware, a program that scrambles files so they cannot be used.

Customers felt it quickly. Online orders were suspended. Contactless payments and gift card use stopped working for a time. Some orders were not delivered, refunds were delayed, and the customer rewards program was paused.

News reports linked the attack to a group called Scattered Spider working with a ransomware gang called DragonForce, but M&S did not confirm that. It also did not say exactly how the attackers got in. Experts say groups like this often trick people with phishing and phone calls. Customers were warned to watch for fake messages pretending to be M&S.

Words to know

- **Ransomware:** Malware that locks your files until you pay.
- **Encrypt:** Scramble data so it cannot be read without the key.
- **Availability:** Being able to use your systems and data when you need them.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

THE CYBER DAILY

Hospital Billing Hit by Ransomware

Change Healthcare is a company that handles billing and insurance payments for doctors, hospitals and pharmacies across the United States. In February 2024 a ransomware gang called ALPHV, or BlackCat, broke into its network through a remote-access portal that did not require multi-factor authentication.

The attackers stayed inside for about nine days. They moved around the network, copied sensitive data, and then locked systems with ransomware. Pharmacy claims, medical billing and payment systems that many health providers rely on were disrupted.

The stolen data may include names, Social Security numbers, medical histories, insurance claims and payment details. The company first estimated about 100 million people. In 2025 the estimate rose to about 192.7 million, which reports call the largest health-care data breach in United States history.

Words to know

- **Multi-factor authentication:** Using two or more proofs of identity, such as a password and a phone code.
- **Remote-access portal:** A website or program that lets people log in to a company network from outside.
- **Ransomware gang:** A group of criminals that locks data and demands payment.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

THE CYBER DAILY

Car Factories Go Dark After Cyberattack

Jaguar Land Rover builds cars in factories in the United Kingdom and around the world. On August 31, 2025 it was hit by a cyberattack. On September 1 it paused production. Weeks later the factories were still silent, and staff were told to stay home.

JLR extended the shutdown several times. By late October it was slowly restarting parts of its production. Estimates put the cost to the company at about 50 million pounds every week, and the damage to the British economy at over a billion pounds.

The pause also hurt smaller companies that make parts for JLR. Some of their workers were laid off. A group that calls itself Scattered Lapsus$ Hunters claimed responsibility. News reports did not say how the attackers first got in.

Words to know

- **Supply chain:** The companies that make and deliver the parts and services another company needs.
- **Shutdown:** Stopping work so systems can be checked and cleaned.
- **Availability:** Being able to use your systems and data when you need them.

Your 30-second report answers three questions: What happened? · How did it happen? · What did it cost the victim?

My Breach News Report

Req 4e · Each Warden fills this in

Name: _____ Lodge: _____

Headline of my article: _____

1. What happened?

_____

_____

2. How did it happen?

_____

_____

3. What did it cost the victim?

_____

_____

4. One thing that could have stopped it

_____

_____

My report in one sentence

_____

Counselor initials: _____ Date: _____

Answer Key

Instructor only

	Story	What happened	How	Cost to victim	What could stop it
1	**A Stolen Login Opens the Door to Millions of School Records**	Attackers stole student, parent and teacher records from a company that stores school data.	They used a stolen login for a support portal, then a maintenance tool to reach school databases.	About 62 million people had personal data exposed, some with Social Security numbers, and the company faced extortion demands.	Protect support logins with multi-factor authentication, and give staff only the access they need.
2	**Chat App's Help Desk Partner Breached**	Criminals stole user information from a company that does customer support for a chat app.	They broke into the third-party support provider, not Discord's main servers.	Names, emails, support chats and some billing details were exposed. A few users also had ID photos exposed. Discord faced a ransom demand.	Share as little as possible with support teams, and be careful with emails or calls about a breach.
3	**Reused Passwords Let Hackers Into a DNA Website**	Hackers got into customer accounts at a DNA testing company and saw family and ancestry information.	Credential stuffing: they reused usernames and passwords leaked from other sites on 23andMe.	About 14,000 accounts were opened and information on about 6.9 million people was exposed. Genetic and family information cannot be changed like a password.	Use a different password for every site, and turn on two-factor authentication.
4	**Big Store Chain Hit by Ransomware**	A big retailer's computer systems were locked by ransomware and online shopping stopped.	Attackers got into the network earlier, then locked servers. The company did not say how they got in.	Online orders were suspended, payments and gift cards stopped for a time, and refunds were delayed.	Keep backups, limit who can reach what, and train staff to spot phishing and phone tricks.
5	**Hospital Billing Hit by Ransomware**	Ransomware hit a company that processes billing and payments for health care providers.	Attackers used a remote-access portal with no multi-factor authentication, stayed in for about nine days, then locked systems.	Pharmacy and billing systems were disrupted, and data on about 192.7 million people may have been exposed.	Require multi-factor authentication on every remote login and watch for strange activity.
6	**Car Factories Go Dark After Cyberattack**	A cyberattack on a car company shut down its factories for weeks.	The way in was not reported. A hacker group claimed responsibility.	Production stopped for weeks, the company lost an estimated 50 million pounds per week, and small parts suppliers laid off workers.	Plan for outages, keep backups that are separate from the main network, and practice restarting.

Points to bring out

Several of these started with a login: a stolen login (PowerSchool), reused passwords (23andMe), and a remote login with no multi-factor authentication (Change Healthcare). Others show that you depend on other companies' security (Discord's support partner). Ransomware stops people from using systems (M&S, JLR, Change Healthcare).

Sources (read in October 2026)

- Lodge 1: techtarget.com/whatis/feature/PowerSchool-data-breach-Explaining-how-it-happened
- Lodge 2: malwarebytes.com/blog/news/2025/10/discord-warns-users-after-data-stolen-in-third-party-breach
- Lodge 3: fox35orlando.com/news/23andme-blames-users-data-breach-citing-recycled-passwords
- Lodge 4: helpnetsecurity.com/2025/04/29/marks-spencer-ransomware-breach-incident
- Lodge 5: cyberinsider.com/change-healthcare-revises-breach-impact-to-192-7-million-individuals
- Lodge 6: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jaguar_Land_Rover_cyberattack

Facts are as reported at the time. Some details, such as who was responsible and how attackers got in, were unconfirmed or disputed. The articles say so where that applies.